

EIGHTH EDITION

Keen's Latin American Civilization

History & Society, 1492 to the Present

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way to a liberal one, allowing Benito Juárez to lead a Reforma [reform movement] that sought the installation of modern capitalism and a Constitution that would protect civil liberties. Legislation on communal land was passed in those areas where collective ownership (whether Indian or ecclesiastical) was an obstacle to private landownership. Juan B. Alberdi—an opponent of Rosas's dictatorship in the 1830s—became the inspiration for the new Argentine leadership in its promotion of immigration, education, and an economic system increasingly focused on the export of foodstuffs. European immigrants arrived in Brazil as well, attracted by the strong incentives offered by the government. As in other societies, port cities grew steadily, generating urban middle and lower classes that acquired increasingly demanding habits of consumption.

Yet, these new winds of optimism, material progress, and liberal politics were at odds with certain harsh realities. Slavery continued in Brazil and Cuba, and its legacy would haunt these societies long after abolition. Indian oppression was ubiquitous in Peru, Mexico, and many other societies. Indeed, the situation of rural villages worsened with the loss of communal land, exposing rural workers to the worst kind of debt peonage. The modern, educated, industrious communities (modeled on European or North American ideals) that Latin American liberal elites imagined for their nations were directly contradicted by many other structural elements of these societies. Despite the changes of the time, the challenges brought by the persistent gap between the communities as imagined and the realities of Latin American nations would remain.

1. ROADS TO THE FUTURE

Another important struggle between Spanish-American liberalism and conservatism took place in Argentina between 1830 and 1852. Against the tyranny of Juan Manuel Rosas, representing the narrow interests and views of the great cattlemen of the province of Buenos Aires, the cultured youth of the capital rose in romantic but ineffective revolt. In 1852, Rosas fell, buried under the weight of the many enemies, domestic and foreign, that his policies had aroused. On the eve of the convention of 1853, summoned to draft a new constitution for Argentina, a book by Juan Bautista Alberdi (1810–1884) appeared, entitled Bases and Points of Departure for the Political Organization of the Argentine Republic, which strongly influenced the work of the delegates. The following selections from this book illustrate the optimistic, "civilizing," and pragmatic temper of Argentine liberalism in the age of Alberdi, Mitre, and Sarmiento.

Juan Bautista Alberdi, *Bases y puntos de partida para la organización política de la República Argentina* (Buenos Aires, 1951), pp. 62–63, 85–88, 90–92, 240–245. Excerpts translated by Benjamin Keen and the editors.

Our youth should be trained for industrial life, and therefore should be educated in the arts and sciences that would prepare them for industry. The South American type of man should be one formed for the conquest of the great and oppressive enemies of our progress: the desert, material backwardness, the brutal and primitive nature of this continent.

We should therefore endeavor to draw our youth away from the cities of the interior, where the old order with its habits of idleness, conceit, and dissipation prevails, and to attract them to the coastal towns so that they may obtain inspiration from Europe, which extends to our shores, and from the spirit of modern life.

The coastal towns, by their very nature, are better schools than our pretentious universities. . . .

Industry is the grand means of promoting morality. By furnishing men with the means of getting a living you keep them from crime, which is generally the fruit of misery and idleness. You will find it useless to fill the minds of youths with abstract notions about religion if you leave them idle and poor. Unless they take monastic vows they will be corrupt and fanatical at the same time. England and the United States have arrived at religious morality by way of industry; Spain has failed to acquire industry and liberty by means of religion alone. Spain has never been guilty of irreligion, but that did not save her from poverty, corruption, and despotism. . . .

The railroad offers the means of righting the topsy-turvy order that Spain established on this continent. She placed the heads of our states where the feet should be. For her ends of isolation and monopoly this was a wise system; for our aims of commercial expansion and freedom it is disastrous. We must bring our capitals to the coast, or rather bring the coast into the interior of the continent. The railroad and the electric telegraph, the conquerors of space, work this wonder better than all the potentates on earth. The railroad changes, reforms, and solves the most difficult problems without decrees or mob violence.

It will forge the unity of the Argentine Republic better than all our congresses. The congresses may declare it "one and indivisible," but without the railroad to connect its most remote regions it will always remain divided and divisible, despite all the legislative decrees.

Without the railroad you will not have political unity in lands where distance nullifies the action of the central government. Do you want the government, the legislators, the courts of the coastal capital to legislate and judge concerning the affairs of the provinces of San Juan and Mendoza, for example? Bring the coast to those regions with the railroad, or vice versa; place those widely separated points within three days' travel of each other, at least. But to have the metropolis or capital a twenty days' journey away is little better than having it in Spain, as it was under the old system, which we overthrew for presenting precisely this absurdity. Political unity, then, should begin with territorial unity, and only the railroad can make a single region of two regions separated by five hundred leagues.

Nor can you bring the interior of our lands within reach of Europe's immigrants, who today are regenerating our coasts, except with the powerful aid of the railroads. They are or will be to the life of our interior territories what the great arteries are to the inferior extremities of the human body: sources of life....

The means for securing railroads abound in these lands. Negotiate loans abroad, pledge your national revenues and properties for enterprises that will make them prosper and multiply. It would be childish to hope that ordinary revenues may suffice for such large expenditures; invert that order, begin with expenditures, and you will have revenues. If we had waited until we had sufficient revenues to bear the cost of the War of Independence against Spain, we would still be colonists. With loans we obtained cannons, guns, ships, and soldiers, and we won our independence. What we did to emerge from slavery, we should do to emerge from backwardness, which is the same as slavery; there is no greater title to glory than civilization.

But you will not obtain loans if you do not have national credit—that is, a credit based on the united securities and obligations of all the towns of the state. With the credits of town councils and provinces you will not secure railroads or anything notable. Form a national body, consolidate the securities of your present and future revenues and wealth, and you will find lenders who will make available millions for your local and general needs; for if you lack money today, you will have the means of becoming opulent tomorrow. Dispersed and divided, expect nothing but poverty and scorn....

The great rivers, those "moving roads," as Pascal called them, are yet another means of introducing the civilizing action of Europe into the interior of our continent by means of her immigrants. But rivers that are not navigated do not, for practical purposes, exist. To place them under the exclusive domination of our poor banners is to close them to navigation. If they are to achieve the destiny assigned to them by God of populating the interior of the continent, we must place them under the law of the sea—that is, open them to an absolute freedom of navigation....

Let the light of the world penetrate every corner of our republics. By what right do we maintain our most beautiful regions in perpetual brutality? Let us grant to European civilization what our ancient masters denied. In order to exercise their monopoly, the essence of their system, they gave only one port to the Argentine Republic; and we have preserved the exclusivism of the colonial system in the name of patriotism. No more exclusion or closure, whatever be the pretext that is invoked. No more exclusivism in the name of the Fatherland....

What name will you give a land with 200,000 leagues of territory and a population of 800,000? A desert. What name will you give the constitution of that country? The constitution is a desert. Very well, the Argentine Republic is that country—and whatever its constitution, for many years it will be nothing more than the constitution of a desert.

But what constitution best fits a desert? One that will help to make it disappear: one that will enable it in the shortest possible time to cease being a desert and become a populated country. This, then, should and must be the political aim of the Argentine constitution and in general of all South American constitutions. The constitutions of unpopulated countries can have no other serious and rational end, at present and for many years to come, than to give the solitary and abandoned countryside the population it requires, as a fundamental condition for its development and progress.

Independent America is called upon to complete the work begun and left unfinished by the Spain of 1450. The colonization, the settlement of this world, new to this day despite the three hundred years that have passed since its discovery, must be completed by the sovereign and independent American states. The work is the same; only its authors are different. At that time Spain settled our lands; today we settle them ourselves. All our constitutions must be aimed at this great end. We need constitutions, we need a policy of creation, of settlement, of conquest of the solitude and the desert....

The end of constitutional policy and government in America, then, is essentially economic. In America, to govern is to populate....

How will the vivifying spirit of the European civilization come to our land? The same way it came in all periods: Europe will bring us its new spirit, its habits of industry, its practices of civilization, in the immigrations it will send to us.

Each European that comes to our shores brings us more civilization in the habits that he communicates to our inhabitants than are contained in many books of philosophy. Perfection that cannot be seen or touched is hard to understand. A laboring man is the most edifying catechism.

Do we want to plant and adapt in America, English freedom, French culture, the industriousness of the man of Europe and the United States? Let us bring living pieces of them in the customs of their inhabitants, and let's settle them here.

Do we want habits of order, discipline, and industry to prevail in our America? Let's fill it with people who will have those deep habits. They communicate; next to the European industrial attitude, the American industrial attitude will soon emerge. The plant of civilization doesn't spread from seeds. It's like the vine; it grows from a torn-off branch.

This is the only way America, today a desert, will turn into an opulent world in a short time. Reproduction alone is a very slow way.

If we want to see our states become bigger in a short time, let's bring from outside its element already formed and prepared.

Without big populations, there is no development of culture, no meaningful progress; everything is mean and small. Nations with half a million inhabitants, they may be according to their expanse of territory, but according to their population they'll be provinces, villages; and all of their things will carry the mean stamp of the province.

Important notice to South American men of state: primary schools, high schools, universities, are, in themselves, very poor ways to progress without the big enterprises of production—children of the great portions of men.

The population—the South American need that represents all the others—is the exact measure of the capacity of our governments. The minister of state who doesn't double the census of these peoples every ten years, has wasted his time in trifles and trivialities.

Make the *rota*, the *gancheo*, the *cholo*, the elemental unit of our popular masses, go through all the transformations of the best system of instruction; but in a hundred years you won't make out of him an English worker, who labors, consumes and lives with dignity and comfort. Put the million inhabitants that constitute the average population of these Republics, in the best possible place for education . . . will you have a great and flourishing state as a result? Certainly not: a million men in a territory that can accommodate 50 million, is that anything other than a pitifully small population?

This argument is made: educating our masses, we'll have order: having order the foreign population will come.

I'll tell you that this argument reverses the true method of progress. It will produce neither order nor popular education except through the influx of masses with deep seeded habits of order and good education.

Multiply the serious population, and you'll see those vain agitators, disregarded and alone, with their plans for frivolous revolts, in the middle of a world absorbed with grave occupations.

2. THE GUANO BOOM

During the second half of the tumultuous nineteenth century, many Latin American nations experienced a series of economic booms and busts. One of the earliest and longest of these booms was in guano, the manure of sea birds found in huge quantities on islands off the coast of Peru. The Peruvian guano boom lasted from the mid-1840s to around 1880 and, as the following excerpt from 1845 demonstrates, it sparked tremendous optimism, speculation, and corruption in both the public and private sectors. This "exposition" to the Peruvian congress by two disgruntled speculators also reveals some of the international economic implications (and pitfalls) of a classic boom cycle. Despite (and probably because of) the incredible profits generated by these booms, they contributed significantly to the region's seemingly chronic political, economic, and social instability—and somewhat paradoxically to its economic underdevelopment vis-à-vis Western Europe and the United States.

Francisco Quiros and Aquiles Allier, "Exposición que don Francisco Quiros y don Aquiles Allier eleven al soberano congreso" (Lima: Imprenta del Correo Peruano, 1845). Excerpt translated by the editors.

Don Francisco Quiros and Don Aquiles Allier, both businessmen of this Capital [Lima], with due respect, present ourselves to Congress and declare: That it is today unquestionable that the idea of applying the use of guano from the [Pacific] islands to European agriculture will be a source of incalculable benefits for Peru and that in the near future, thanks to this idea, the Republic will be able to count on vast resources taken exclusively from a sector that had in the past always been sterile and unproductive for the national treasury.

His Excellency the President of the Republic did Peru a distinct service when, disregarding uniformed concerns, he agreed to admit the proposals that Don Francisco Quiros made to the government with the object of launching into the world of commerce this commodity hitherto unknown outside our coastal region. And it is now commonly acknowledged that this fertilizer enjoys wide acceptance in countries where it has been tried and in particular in Great Britain. It is impossible to calculate the immense profits that Peru will realize from a source of wealth over which it has almost exclusive control.

It is true that off the coast of Africa, they have discovered some substantial guano deposits that have paralyzed, inevitably but momentarily, Peruvian operations. But if this discovery is prejudicial to the interests of currently operating businesses, it is undeniable that its results, far from being harmful to Peru, will be in reality and in short order advantageous.

Because most of these deposits were found on rocks and uninhabited islets, they have been considered ownerless and available to all those who wished to exploit them. As a result, an immense number of owners and captains of ships have speculated on the extraction and transportation of this fertilizer to the ports of Great Britain, the Antilles, and other parts of the globe where they hope to encounter a market. A violent rise in exports far in excess of demand has resulted from these heated speculations. A decline in price, resulting from this lack of balance between the supply of this commodity and the demand for it, has convinced farmers, so stubborn in their routines, to abandon traditional and accepted fertilizers in order to try this new one that is being offered so cheaply.

In order to take advantage of these temporary and short-lived circumstances, Peru should move quickly to propagate the knowledge and use of guano to all the agricultural regions of Europe and America, something that would never have happened without the discovery of African guano, since Peru would not have wanted to sell a similar quantity at cost as happened with that extracted off the coast of Africa which was sold without profit since the market price of guano could not cover the cost of the freight and the expense of shipping from the African coast.

While the African deposits supply the foreign markets, the extraction of Peruvian guano will remain largely paralyzed but will resume operations with vigor and benefit as soon as the strength and power of its adversary diminishes; such that Peru in probably a very short time will come to see itself in an advantageous position relative to African guano, which meanwhile will have spread the use of guano and made it one of the necessities of foreign agriculture.

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MODERNITY AND THE EMERGENCE OF THE NATION-STATE

AS THEY CONSOLIDATED THEIR PLACE as producers of raw materials and foodstuffs during the last quarter of the nineteenth century, Latin American economies also further consolidated their path toward modernity. Argentina was probably the most spectacular case: With every indicator of economic expansion skyrocketing, hundreds of thousands of European immigrants arrived every year to settle permanently. But a similar tendency was evident everywhere else on the continent. Key areas of the export economy were in foreign hands—particularly those that were technologically complex. Railways carried commodities from the producing areas to the port, sugar mills, refrigerated meat-packing plants, and grain storage silos. Indeed, some countries—particularly in Central America and the Caribbean—saw the development of foreign enclaves within their territories, areas that were increasingly isolated from neighboring zones as they modernized their infrastructure and developed according to the demands of foreign markets. Prosperity, however, did not mean economic stability, since the oscillations of the international market could quickly lead these dependent national economies from feverish growth to total collapse in short periods of time.

This general context of export-led prosperity, however, allowed political elites to consolidate their power, as the dominant climate of ideas shifted gradually from mid-century liberalism toward a more conservative—even authoritarian—conception of politics. A new type of “progressive” *caudillo*—Díaz in Mexico, Núñez in Colombia, Guzmán Blanco in Venezuela, Barrios in Guatemala—symbolizes this era of pragmatic liberalism. The phrase “Order and Progress,” a motto used by political leaders themselves, encapsulates

the importance attached to both the concentration of power in the hands of the executive branch and to material prosperity. Traditional liberal claims for civil liberties and constitutional methods of government were no longer central to liberalism. Regional revolts did not disappear completely, but they became increasingly rare as states, in pursuit of a monopoly on violence, centralized and professionalized their armed forces. Material prosperity also allowed states to expand and streamline their bureaucracies, a fact reflected in the imposing state buildings that multiplied throughout the capital cities. Political discourse took a decidedly positivistic turn. The prestige of science persuaded leaders to associate their administrations with the languages and views of reform provided by medicine and biology.

As the century drew to a close, dissatisfied urban middle- and working-class groups combined to form parties that challenged the political establishments in a number of countries. Interestingly, the economic systems of these countries remained beyond major ideological challenge until the first decades of the following century. Democratic or Radical parties, quite moderate in their demands, challenged the political elites on moral grounds. While the first Socialist groups arose in Chile and Argentina as early as the 1890s, their historical moment would come later.

1. POLITICAL STABILITY AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

The year 1880 represents a turning point in the process of state and nation building in Argentina. The end of the "Indian problem," officially settled with the "Campaign of the Desert" (as the final stages of the war against the Indians were called), eliminated one of the main barriers to economic expansion, opening up vast tracts of new land and subjugating about 14,000 Indians. Thanks to the prestige he gained as the military leader of this undertaking (1879–1880) and to the endorsement by a broad coalition of governors and Buenos Aires political factions, Julio A. Roca won the presidential election. One of the most contentious issues—it caused an uprising after Roca's electoral triumph—was the location of the nation's capital (later resolved with the federalization of Buenos Aires and the foundation of La Plata, a new capital for the province of Buenos Aires). Delivered in this unsettled context, Roca's presidential inauguration speech exhibits a concern for civil order, and a strong assertion of the legitimacy of the state's use of violence over dissident groups—so strongly emphasized perhaps because it had so often been contested ever since the promulgation of the Con-

General Julio A. Roca, "Discurso ante el Congreso al asumir la presidencia," *La Prensa*, October 13, 1880. Excerpt translated by the editors.

stitution in 1853. In Roca's view, the consolidation of state authority would bring order and peace. Material progress would naturally follow.

When it comes to the freedom and betterment of peoples, nothing great, nothing stable or durable can be achieved in the world without supreme effort and painful sacrifice. The hard tests that the Argentine Republic has been through should not surprise us, especially when we contemplate the rapid progress and compare the conquests made in our half-century of national life with the slow march of the governments of the most advanced societies. We live at a quick pace, and in our feverish impatience to one day reach the level that other peoples have achieved after centuries of work and bloody trials, we are surprised by, and unprepared for, many of the larger problems of our political and social organization.

The Congress of 1880 has complemented the system of representative, federal Government, and it can be said that only as of today has the rule of the Constitution been fully established. The law that you have just passed, establishing the definitive capital of the Republic, marks the beginning of a new era in which the government will be able to freely deploy its force, unfettered by the daily and depressing challenges to its authority that it had to face as it defended its rights against the invasive pretensions of subaltern functionaries. This law responds to the highest aspiration of the people, because it means the consolidation of the union, and the establishment of peace for many years to come. Its achievement was an inevitable necessity, and having so faithfully interpreted its support will entitle you to the gratitude of the Republic.

From now on, free from the worries and internal commotion that threatened everything, including the very integrity of the Republic, at each step the government will now be able to devote itself to the task of administration and to the labors of fruitful peace. The revolutionary era, which has continually hindered our regular march, is closed forever, and we will shortly harvest the fruits of your wise choice and integrity.

In assuming the general administration of the country, two main concerns prevail over all others: the army and the communication routes.

The army and the navy, which secure the integrity and protection of the motherland in the exterior as well as its internal peace and order, must claim the preferential attention of Congress and the new government. The Republic can count on an army that is exemplary in its self-abnegation, resilient, brave in combat, loyal, and faithful to its flag. But it lives at the mercy of arbitrariness, devoid of rules or laws that organize it under a regular and systematic plan. I will devote my greatest efforts to the reforms that are needed in this area, in order to avoid the dangers of militarism—in other words, the possibility of the suppression of liberty at some point in the future, and to turn the army into a true institution, which both the Constitution and modern progress require. In this way, immune from the movement of political parties, and exalted as it

more elegant, with a British correctness (slightly out of place, because what suits the English and their affected rigidity, their stiffness and phlegm, does not suit the vivacious and spontaneous Latins). One certainly finds shinier shoes here than in any part of Europe. One notices their taste for polish, and the cleanliness of their feet, whether varnished or polished, remind me of those of Athenians and Spaniards.

The impression of prosperity and luxury grows even more if one visits the western neighborhoods, as sumptuous as our Passy or our Plaine-Monceau, though with greater variety and even more private hotels, some quite exquisite. In certain areas, they remind one of Berlin or, even better, Charlottenburg, Schoeneberg, or Wilmsdorf with its new streets of houses, only more stylish and elegant.

The tidiness of the streets, the regularity and frequency with which they are cleaned, also reminds one of German towns. Men with small brooms and shovels work constantly in the busiest streets, cleaning and sweeping all day

3. A DIFFERENT MODEL OF ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT: A NEW PROGRAM FOR CHILE

The formula for Argentine development advocated by Alberdi (see Chapter 13, "Roads to the Future"), with its stress on opening the country to European capital, commerce, and immigrants, may be described as the classic nineteenth-century developmental model and was accepted by most Latin American countries. That model, which flourished from about 1870 to 1914, came to be based on the exchange of a few staples, foodstuffs, and raw materials for European and North American finished goods. Such exchange brought greater political stability and some prosperity to the area, but in the long run it created serious problems of dependency (neocolonialism) and underdevelopment. This model was not, however, the only possible or inevitable model for the area. In Paraguay, between 1811 and 1866, a state-directed program of autonomous economic development turned Paraguay into one of the most progressive and prosperous states in South America. This progress was destroyed by the terrible Paraguayan War of 1865-1870, which pitted Paraguay against Argentina and Brazil. In Chile, in the 1880s, President José Manuel Balmaceda offered a nationalistic program for a many-sided economic development that included the promotion of native industry and the Chileanization of the British-dominated nitrate industry. His program provoked a revolt by conservative forces, supported by British interests, that led to Balmaceda's defeat and suicide in 1891. The following excerpts from his speeches suggest the main thrust of his program.

Fernando Silva Vargas, ed., *El pensamiento de Balmaceda* (Santiago de Chile, 1974), pp. 67-88-88. Excerpts translated by Benjamin Keen.

On the Need to Develop National Industry

Economic developments of the last few years prove that, while maintaining a just balance between expenditures and income, we can and should undertake productive national works that will nourish, more especially, our public education and our national industry.

And since I speak of our national industry, I must add that it is weak and uncertain because of lack of confidence on the part of capital and because of our general resistance to opening up and utilizing its beneficial currents.

If, following the example of Washington and the great republic of the North, we preferred to consume our national production, even if it is not as finished and perfect as the foreign production; if the farmer, the miner, and the manufacturer constructed their tools and machines whenever possible in our country's workshops; if we broadened and made more varied the production of our raw materials, processing and transforming them into objects useful for life or personal comfort; if we ennobled industrial labor, increasing wages in proportion to the greater skill of our working class; if the state, while maintaining a balance between revenues and expenditures, devoted a portion of its resources to the protection of national industry, nourishing and supporting it during its first trials; if the state, with its resources and legislation, and all of us together, collectively and singly, applied ourselves to producing more and better, and consuming what we produce, then a more vigorous sap would circulate through the industrial organism of the Republic, and increased wealth and well-being would give us the possession of that supreme good of an industrious and honorable people: the capacity to live and clothe ourselves by our own unaided efforts.

On the Concentration of Chile's Nitrate Wealth in Foreign Hands

The extraction and processing of nitrate must be left to the free competition of the industry itself. But the question of the privately owned and government-owned nitrate properties is a matter for serious meditation and study. The private properties are almost all foreign owned, and effectively concentrated in the hands of individuals of a single [British] nationality. It would be preferable that these properties belonged to Chileans as well; but if our national capital is indolent or fearful, we must not be surprised if foreign capital fills, with foresight and intelligence, the void in the progress of this region [Tarapacá] left by the neglect of our compatriots....

The importance of nitrate in agriculture and industry and the growing tempo of its production counsel the legislator and the statesman not to delay the solution of the problem, and to resolve it by effectively protecting the

interests of our nationals. It is true that this must not be done in such a way as to effectively stifle free competition and production of nitrate in Tarapaca, but neither should we allow that vast and rich area to become a mere foreign enclave. We cannot ignore the very real and serious fact that the peculiar nature of the industry, the manner in which the nitrate properties came into being, the absorption of small properties by foreign capital, and even the temper of the races that dispute the dominion of that vast and fertile region, demand a special legislation, based on the nature of things and the special needs of our economic and industrial existence. This question has such profound consequences for the future that upon its solution will in large part depend the development of our private wealth, today removed from that fecund center of labor and general prosperity.

4. PORFIRIO DÍAZ ASSESSES HIS LEGACY

For nearly thirty-five years (1876–1911), Mexico was under the effective control of one man, General Porfirio Díaz. According to the regime's propagandists, this prolonged period of relative stability had provided a much needed respite from contentious politics and a golden opportunity for economic development under the expert guidance of Díaz's cadre of loyal científicos (technocrats). Economic development, in turn, was promoting the development of democratic sensibilities in the Mexican people through expanded educational and employment opportunities. Much of that economic development would come from increased foreign investment drawn by generous financial incentives and guarantees of security. In this famous 1908 interview with American journalist James Creelman, Porfirio Díaz demonstrates his understanding of this developmentalist agenda as well as his mastery of public relations. The promise of free elections in the upcoming presidential campaign, probably intended for American rather than Mexican readers, encouraged the development of a political opposition that would eventually put an end to Díaz's authoritarian rule.

"It is a mistake to suppose that the future of democracy in Mexico has been endangered by the long continuance in office of one President," he said quietly. "I can say sincerely that office has not corrupted my political ideals and that I believe democracy to be the one true, just principle of government, although in practice it is possible only to highly developed peoples." . . .

"I received this Government from the hands of a victorious army at a time when the people were divided and unprepared for the exercise of the

extreme principles of democratic government. [Díaz came to power in a military coup in 1876 after a disputed election.] To have thrown upon the masses the whole responsibility of government at once would have produced conditions that might have discredited the cause of free government."

"Yet, although I got power at first from the army, an election was held as soon as possible and then my authority came from the people. I have tried to leave the Presidency several times, but it has been pressed upon me and I remained in office for the sake of the nation which trusted me. The fact that the price of Mexican securities dropped eleven points when I was ill at Cuernavaca indicates the kind of evidence that persuaded me to overcome my personal inclination to retire to private life."

"We preserved the republican and democratic form of government. We defended the theory and kept it intact. Yet we adopted a patriarchal policy in the actual administration of the nation's affairs, guiding and restraining popular tendencies, with full faith that an enforced peace would allow education, industry and commerce to develop elements of stability and unity in a naturally intelligent, gentle and affectionate people."

"I have waited patiently for the day when the people of the Mexican Republic would be prepared to choose and change their government at every election without danger of armed revolutions and without injury to the national credit or interference with national progress. I believe that day has come." . . .

"It is commonly held true that democratic institutions are impossible in a country which has no middle class," I [Creelman] suggested.

President Díaz turned, with a keen look, and nodded his head.

"It is true," he said. "Mexico has a middle class now; but she had none before. The middle class is the active element of society, here as elsewhere."

"The rich are too much preoccupied in their riches and in their dignities to be of much use in advancing the general welfare. Their children do not try very hard to improve their education or their character."

"On the other hand, the poor are usually too ignorant to have power."

"It is upon the middle class, drawn largely from the poor, but somewhat from the rich, the active, hard-working, self-improving middle class, that a democracy must depend for its government. It is the middle class that concerns itself with politics and with the general progress."

"In the old days we had no middle class in Mexico because the minds of the people and their energies were wholly absorbed in politics and war. Spanish tyranny and misgovernment had disorganized society. The productive activities of the nation were abandoned in successive struggles. There was general confusion. Neither life nor property was safe. A middle class could not appear under such conditions." . . .

"The future of Mexico is assured," he said in a clear voice. "The principles of democracy have not been planted very deep in our people, I fear. But the nation has grown and it loves liberty. Our difficulty has been that the

James Creelman, "President Díaz, Hero of the Americas," *Pearson's Magazine* 19, no. 3 (March 1908), pp. 234–245.